

Innovation Is Also About Improving Everyday Objects

Innovation is not just about creating new technologies and products but also about improving everyday objects such as, say, saucepans or fruit bowls with the use of technology. While it might seem quite futuristic to have a saucepan with a chip in it, that might happen in the future as chip costs really go down and people realise the joy of not having to sponge up spilt milk! Here we are with this month's dose of inspiration, which includes a few such 'everyday' objects too

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No scratches from this foldable power plug

What do you do when a power plug's pins scratch your laptop or desk? A lot of us might have just mumbled about it, but when Min-Kyu Choi took a scratch from a power plug in 2009, while studying at London's Royal Academy, he started redesigning the ubiquitous power plug together with friend Matthew Judkins. The foldable power plug designed by the duo is a radically new design that can fit in the user's pocket. The design won prestigious design awards, and is now being manufactured and marketed as the Mu Foldable Plug, through their London-based startup Made in Mind.

What's inside: Redesigning the power plug is no easy task, since it has been in its current form for decades now, and people have fixed notions about how a power plug should look and work. So, when Choi and Judkins started redesigning this everyday product, they first analysed the whole element of the product, and figured out what could or could not be changed. What could not change, due to standardisation, were the dimensions of the pins. So they just rearranged the pin positions so that the end-product could be made slimmer. The result of their design explorations is a technology called PVT that allows the live and neutral pins, on the bottom of the plug, to pivot 90 degrees so they align with the earth pin on the top. The two flaps on the side then collapse, helping push everything into a little compartment that measures only $14 \times 55 \times 60 \text{ mm}^3$ – 70 per cent less than standard the UK plug sizes.

The folding power plug took three years to develop and is protected by six patents. It is now available in the market as a USB charger for smartphones, tablets and music players. Its developers are now working on developing a Mu power cord for charging laptops.

Web: <http://www.themu.co.uk>

Smart fruit bowl that detects mould

It can be quite irritating when you pick up a fruit from a bowl and realise that it is spoilt. Not only does it smell and taste rotten, it could also spoil the other fruits in the bowl. How many times have you wished there was some way to know in advance when a fruit is nearing its end-of-life? Jagjit Chodha of Brunel University, London, has designed a smart bowl that could do just that. Showcased at the Made in Brunel 2013 exhibition, the bowl caught the fancy of many a visitor.

What's inside: The solution comprises a sensor system embedded in the fruit bowl, and an array of lights for notification. The sensors monitor the levels of ethylene—a gas released during the ripening process. When the levels increase, it triggers the alarm, which warns the user to consume the fruits before they rot. A seemingly simple solution, it can surely help contain food wastage if developed and manufactured at a reasonable cost.

Web: <http://madeinbrunel.com>



(Courtesy: Jagjit Chodha)